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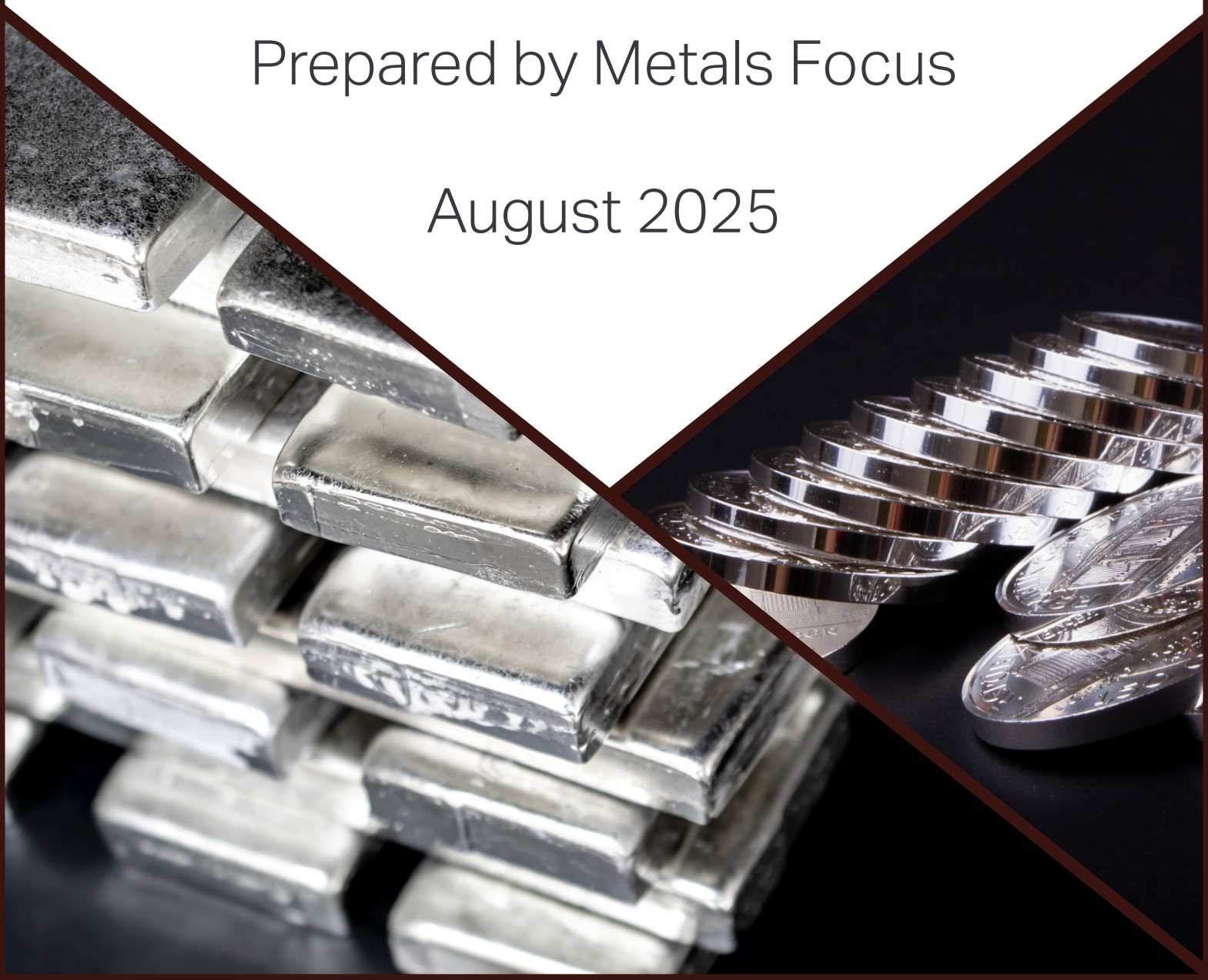
Market Trend Report

Key Physical Silver Investment Markets

Prepared by Metals Focus

August 2025



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Chapter 1

Introduction & Summary

Introduction

Physical investment is an integral part of global silver demand, and is undoubtedly the most volatile. Over the past 15 years it has ranged between a series low of 157.2Moz (4,891t) in 2017 and a record high of 337.6Moz (10,501t), established in 2022. From a market share standpoint, in 2010, total silver bar and coin investment accounted for 20% of global demand. By 2015, its share had jumped to 28%, but just two years later its contribution had fallen to just 16%, a position that has been revisited in 2024 and also, basis Metals Focus' latest forecast, for this year as well.

Another characteristic that stands out is the degree of market concentration. Just four countries, the US, India, Germany and Australia, account for around 80% of global silver physical investment. This compares with around 60% for the top four in the gold market. The final point to note is that the trends in retail investment are not always as straightforward as being an industrialized : emerging market split. It is for these reasons that the Silver Institute commissioned Metals Focus to take a closer look at physical investment in these four markets, providing some historical context, which in turn should help to explain current trends that characterize these countries' silver bar and coin demand.

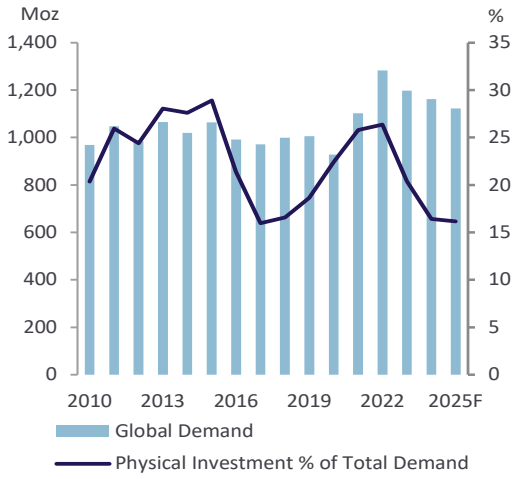
Summary

Looking first at the **US**, this traditionally being the largest physical silver investment market. However, in 2018 and 2019, it was overtaken by India, an outcome which looks set to be repeated this year. This aside, the scale of US buying has been staggering. Between 2010-2024, a combined total of 1.5bn oz (46,160t) was purchased by retail investors, averaging 98.9Moz/y (3,077t). At its height during 2021-23, retail demand averaged a phenomenal 131.5Moz/y (4,091t). One increasingly important driver of US demand over the past decade or so has been the personal pension market, known as Independent Retirement Accounts (IRAs). The popularity of these IRAs has grown sharply, but interestingly those IRAs featuring precious metals still account for a very small share of the total IRA market in the US. This in turn suggests there is still considerable room for precious metal IRA demand to grow.

Another stand-out feature of the US physical investment market through to late-2023 was the exceptionally low level of retail liquidations. As such, much of the 1.5bn oz (46,160t) acquired over the past 15 years is still held by US investors. Even so, selling back first emerged in late 2023 and has continued well into 2025. As such, demand for newly struck coins and bars has fallen sharply so far this year, with total US retail investment likely to hit a seven-year low in 2025.

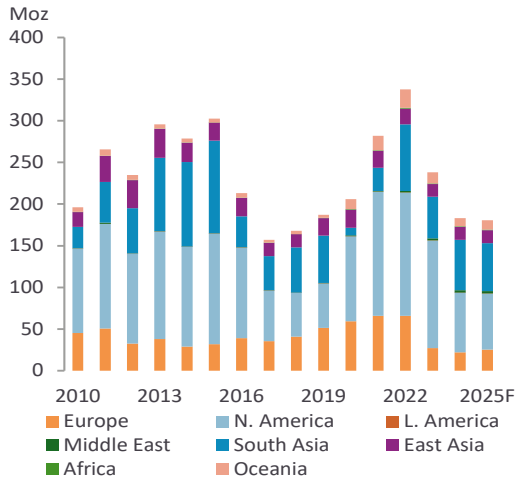
Turning to **India**, this has typically been the world's second largest physical investment market, but on occasion has eclipsed the US to hold the

Global Silver Demand



Source: Metals Focus

Regional Physical Silver Investment



Source: Metals Focus

number one spot. The country has a long-standing tradition of owning physical silver, typically in bar form. To put this into context, between 2010-24, cumulative Indian bar and coin demand stood at 840Moz (26,100t). In a broadly similar fashion to the US, these holdings have generally been quite sticky, reflecting Indian investors' typically bullish price expectations. However, there have been brief periods when the market has seen heavy liquidations, such as in 2020 when the rupee silver price surged. Nonetheless, this selling back has usually been short-lived. It is also quite revealing that in the current market, with the rupee silver price hitting successive records highs and breaking through the psychologically important Rs.100,000/kg level the scale of selling back has been surprisingly modest. This mostly reflects how deeply held positive price expectations are in India, with many investors looking for the international price to revisit its record high in dollar terms.

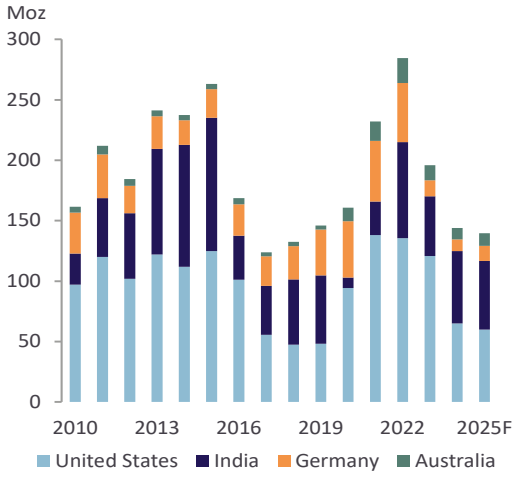
Although this report focuses on bar and coin demand, with regards to India it is worth briefly touching on the exchange-traded product (ETP) market. These were launched there in 2022, but initially struggled to gain much traction. That, however, has changed significantly over the past 18 months or so, with holdings (as of end-June) exceeding 58Moz (1,800t), a jump of 51% since end-2024. While these ETPs do offer an alternative route for Indian investors looking to gain exposure to the silver market, our understanding is that instead they have served to broaden the investor base by appealing to those already active in the equities market, who typically might not have bought physical metal.

In terms of recent trends, Indian physical silver investment surged in 2022, to its highest since 2015. Although purchases fell back sharply in 2023 they remained historically high in absolute terms. Furthermore, 2024 saw a modest recovery, helped by the surprise bullion duty cut in July. That led to a step-change down in the rupee silver price, which encouraged bargain hunting. As a result, leaving aside the 2022 spike in demand, last year's total was the highest since 2015. This year, we forecast a slight drop as further price gains lead to both profit taking and momentum buying. As such, the full year total will still remain historically high.

Looking at **Germany**, this has long-held the position as the third largest market for retail silver bar and coin investment. Even so, it has been noteworthy to see how volatile the market has been in recent years. Between 2012-18, retail purchases in Germany averaged a relatively modest 24.6Moz/y (764t). The market then started to recover before surging as first COVID then Russia's invasion of Ukraine unfolded. As a result, German physical silver investment averaged an eye-watering 48.5Moz (1,510t) during 2020-22. Another factor supporting demand in these years was the tax structure, known as the Margin Tax. This meant that non-European Union silver bullion coins attracted a lower sales tax compared to both other coins and all silver bars.

However, this favorable tax treatment was removed at end-2022. This development, along with crisis fatigue, the ongoing cost-of-living

Top Four Physical Silver Investment Markets



Source: Metals Focus

crisis and the return of positive interest rates led to a collapse in retail purchases. As a result, German silver investment dropped in 2023 to a historic low of just 13.3Moz (308t). These headwinds continued into 2024 resulting in another challenging year. The fall in sales of new bars and coins was amplified by a rise in the selling back of old bullion products by retail investors in response to rising silver prices. To put this into perspective, in just two years, German net silver demand had slumped by 80% or roughly 39Moz (1,200t). (These declines extended to the gold market, which also experienced a collapse in net retail purchases.) By contrast, this year there have so far been indications of a partial recovery (for both silver and gold retail buying), in part as liquidations have eased back. As a result, we forecast an approximate 25% y/y rise, although total German silver and bar coin demand will still remain subdued by historical standards.

Turning finally to **Australia**, over the past five years the country has risen to become the world's fourth largest physical silver investment market. As recently as 2019 however, Australian silver bar and coin demand stood at just 3.5Moz (109t). By 2022, it had surged to a record high of 20.7Moz (644t). As well as the wider macro-related factors driving local demand, two reasons specific to Australia also contributed to this upside, the growing popularity of investing silver in superannuation, or retirement accounts, and the favorable tax structure applicable to physical silver investment products. Chapter 5 further explores the tax regime, but put simply investment-grade silver in Australia is sales tax free, although it is subject to capital gains tax (CGT). Silver invested in retirement accounts attracts different CGT rates if the metal is sold before retirement, but after that point it becomes CGT-free.

In terms of overall market trends, in keeping with the other key markets discussed in this report, Australian retail investment weakened during 2023-24, in part due to profit taking. Regardless, it still remained well above pre-2020 levels. Furthermore, our forecast sees a 11% rise this year as earlier cost-of-living pressures ease (and so with it less selling back). There also appears a growing perception that silver is undervalued compared with gold, which is therefore attracting renewed interest in silver.

Chapter 2

United States

Introduction

The US is by some margin the most important globally for silver retail investment. Since 2010, it has been the largest market in all but two years (2018 and 2019) when a brief lull saw the country cede second place to India. Cumulatively over 2010-24, the US has seen net purchases of a massive 1.48 Bn oz (46,160t), compared to India's 840Moz (26,113t). Much of this flows through from the scale of the US economy, but the tax regime is also favorable to physical silver and there is a strong cultural bond with the metal. By way of illustration, the value of silver investment in the US has averaged around 70% of the value of its citizens' purchases of physical gold compared to just 6% in the rest of the world.

It is also worth noting that silver's popularity in the US has been enduring. During 2010-16, investment averaged 111Moz (3,452t) a year, peaking in 2015 at a then record of 125Moz (3,888t). Much of this was due to the lingering affects of the earlier global financial crisis that had led to the adoption of unorthodox monetary policies, triggering fears of inflation or a more general fiat currency debasement. The following three years up to 2019 however saw a lull, when demand averaged just 50Moz (1,555t). Some of this merely reflected the sheer volume bought earlier and disappointment over subdued prices, but competition from surging equities also featured.

With the onset of COVID however, demand roared back to life, averaging 122Moz (3,795t) during 2020-23 and setting a new record of 138Moz (4,292t) in 2022. The chief drivers here were overspill from gold linked to renewed inflation fears, bank failures and geopolitical conflicts, but silver also benefited from social media campaigns and a widespread belief it was undervalued, certainly in comparison to gold. That belief remains intact and this helps explain why, in the face of profit taking, market saturation and crisis fatigue, demand may have eased, but remains comfortably above the earlier lull.

The most popular product is the US Mint's silver Eagle bullion coin and it is this that helps lift coins' share of total investment to a comparatively high level. Bars (including 1oz rounds) have grown in popularity, chiefly due to their lower margins.

US Silver Physical Investment

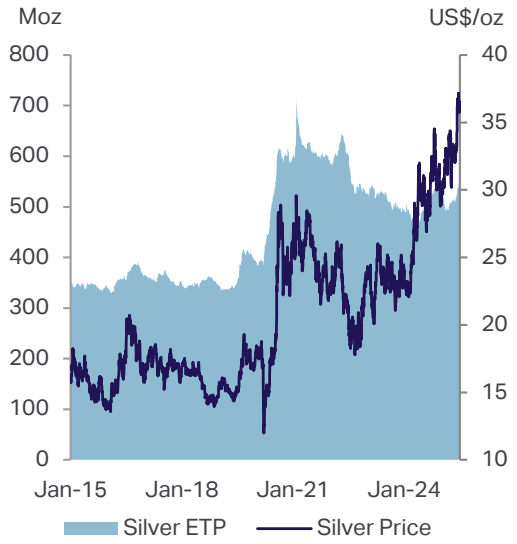
Source: Metals Focus, Bloomberg

The Structure of the US Silver Investment Market

Physical investment and its rival forms

It is worth noting that the purchase of silver coins and (smaller) bars is not the only avenue open to retail investors in the US, and indeed elsewhere. One obvious alternative is **exchange-traded products** (ETPs). Holdings in these products are substantial at 553Moz (17,210t) (as of end-July 2025 for all US-listed products), but are notably down on their historic high in

US Silver ETP Holdings



Source: Metals Focus, Bloomberg

February 2021 of 723Moz (22,488t). It is worth noting that a sizable portion of these are held by retail investors.

Institutional investors account for a yet greater slice of activity in **futures** contracts, in particular the all-important 5,000oz CME contract where they make up at least 90% of volumes. Retail investors instead skew to its 1,000oz micro futures contract, where they are understood to account for a majority of the activity.

Silver mining company **equities** are another option, particularly for those investors that want a leveraged play on the silver price; mining equities generally have a higher beta than the underlying metal as free cash flow and share prices can show outsized moves relative to silver. For example, the silver price may have risen by 37% (basis quarterly averages) from Q4.23 to Q1.25, but producer all-in sustaining cost margins surged by almost 250%.

Lastly, we need to take into account the **over-the-counter** (OTC) market. Much of this is dominated by institutional players, such as hedge funds, but there is also an element of off-exchange vaulted silver. A good portion of this in turn represents investment by family offices and high-net-worth individuals which we do not classify as retail investment, even if the line between the two can be blurred.

Silver versus other precious metals

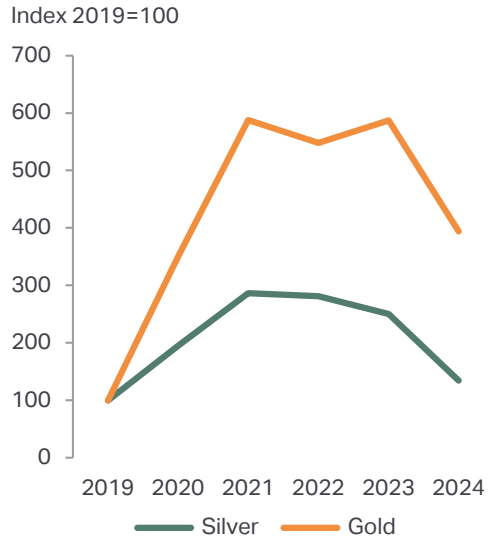
The US is unusual in that physical investment in silver is much more popular in relation to gold compared to many other countries. For example, the value of physical investment in silver averaged 68% of gold investment over 2010-24 compared to just 6% for the rest of the world (basis annual prices and annual volumes, with no product premiums). Indeed, in 2011, 2012 and 2014, US investment in silver was greater than in gold in these dollar terms.

Some of this difference is merely due to taxation policies. Demand in Europe for example is impacted by VAT (usually around 20%) being levied on investment silver, while gold in the region is mostly zero-rated. In contrast, there is no federal sales tax imposed on investment silver, but it can exist at the state level. The vast majority of states offer full exemptions on investment silver, if at times with various qualifications.

Some of this country-level difference is also down to cultural differences as the US shows an enthusiasm for silver that tends not to be replicated elsewhere. An element of this is linked to those investors who are by nature wary of government per se and like the idea of an asset with no counterparty that could in theory be used for transactions.

Another supportive factor within the US relates to those saving in individual retirement accounts (IRAs). Silver has been a frequent recommendation for those using these savings vehicles (often due to a belief in silver being undervalued in comparison to gold) and the amount

Gold & Silver Physical Investment



Source: Metals Focus

of silver held in such accounts has grown hugely in recent years as savers take advantage of the favorable tax regime behind this.

A small group of investors may also show interest in platinum and on occasion palladium. However, it would be unwise to see either as a rival to silver as both PGMs are traded on an investor's belief in each metal's specific supply/demand story and/or its pricing relative to other precious metals, invariably gold.

The product structure of US physical investment in silver

Coins

The US is somewhat unusual in the greater share of investment going into coins – from 2010 to 2024, this accounted for around 55% of the market compared to just 45% in the rest of the world. This popularity stems from: the availability of sovereign mint bullion coins (both domestically and from overseas); the greater potential for using coins as a means of exchange in times of extreme crisis and some investors' belief that there can be upside potential for a coin's premium.

As touched on above, the US Mint's silver Eagle bullion coin tends to dominate coin purchases in the US. The other major North American silver bullion coin, the Royal Canadian Mint's Maple Leaf also commands an important share of the US market. Other prominent silver bullion coins retailing in the US include the Austrian Mint's Philharmonic, the Perth Mint's Kookaburra, Kangaroo and Koala, the Rand Refinery's Krugerrand and the UK Royal Mint's Britannia.

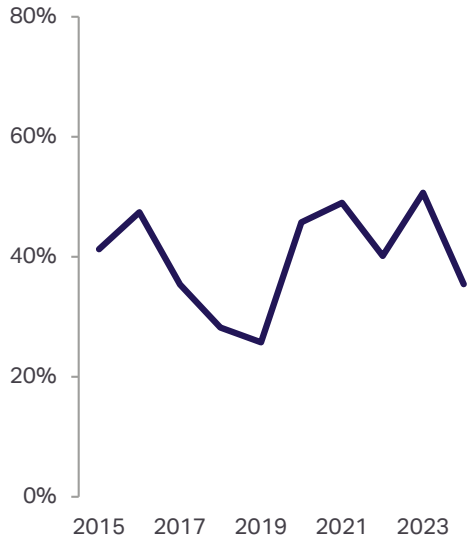
There is also regular striking of commemorative coins minted each year. However, we account for the fabrication of these coins in our overall demand numbers, but we do not include them within retail investment due to the very different motivations for buying and their far higher premiums. The buying and selling of numismatic coins is also not included since, not only are the rationale and margins again distinct from bullion coins, but there is also no net call on the silver bullion market as no product is being fabricated.

Bars

Silver bars' share of total US retail investment has shown something of an upward path over the last decade or so. Some of this is due to semi-structural changes, such as the gains for silver going into IRA accounts. Another factor was coin shortages, which obliged investors to shift to bars. All this explains why bars' share rose from under 40% in 2015-16 to almost 55% in 2022 but has since eased back to around 40%.

The standard product on sale was minted 1oz, 5oz, 10oz, 100oz and, on occasion, kilobars. Within this group, we include 1oz rounds, which while similar in appearance to the above above-mentioned 1oz bullion coins are struck by private mints and carry a far lower premium than sovereign

US Share of Global Physical Silver Investment



Source: Metals Focus

bullion coins. These rounds grew in popularity during the 2010s due to coin shortages and successful promotions by their manufacturers.

Cast bars also saw a substantial uplift in popularity in recent years as inflated margins and availability issues pushed investors towards these lower margin options. Indeed, some dealers saw cast bars' share of all bars shoot up to around 50%. With supply issues and premiums coming off the boil, cast bars' share has fallen back. Cast bars tend to be larger, with 10oz and 100oz being the norm and kilobars and 1,000oz LBMA Good Delivery bars being acquired (although the latter would normally be purchased by HNW investors).

Features of the composition of investors specific to the US

One interesting feature of silver investment in the US is how it has captured the interest of high net worth investors, who appreciate the absence of counterparty risk and the portfolio diversification qualities of the metal. Others are attracted to silver's inherent volatility and implicitly high potential returns which makes silver in their minds very different to gold with its focus on wealth preservation rather than capital gains. Given the huge number of very wealthy investors in the US, this has the potential to significantly boost retail investment, but as noted earlier much of this is best classified as part of the OTC market, especially when large bars (with their lower margins) are the product of choice. However, there is a gray area between what can be classified as retail versus HNW activity. In contrast, the silver going into IRAs is from a much broader swathe of the population, potentially encompassing anyone with a generously funded retirement program.

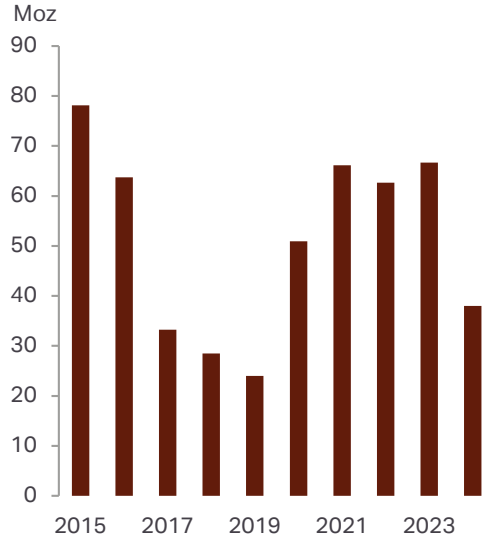
Lower income groups can also be attracted to silver, and indeed many dealers see this group as their most important or at least note a clear preference among such buyers for silver compared to gold. This is seen chiefly as a result of its low unit price (certainly compared to gold) and the ability of the metal to generate exciting returns.

Dealers also often report that in all investor groups there tends to be a skew to Republican voters. On top of a general mistrust of government here, these investors often see silver (and gold) as a necessary defense against the possible mismanagement of the economy and undermining of the value of the dollar by a Democrat administration. Some may even stretch that to seeing Democrats as a threat to individuals' liberties and silver again is seen as protection against that. Indeed, our research shows that there is a visible reaction in US investment to whoever is sitting in the White House.

Long-Term Trends

A review of US retail investment since 2010 reveals three distinct phases: a period of historically high but volatile buying through to 2016, then a three year trough and finally a return to buoyant levels over 2020-2023.

US Bullion Coin Sales



Source: Metals Focus, Quarterly Bullion Coin Survey

The strong opening – 2010 to 2016

The initial two years saw the final stage of the rapid growth seen late on in the previous decade as demand reached a then record high of 119.9Moz (3,729t) in 2011. Much of this stemmed from the lingering impact of the 2008 financial crisis, in particular the inflation concerns triggered by quantitative easing programs and the still shaky state of the US economy, which did much to boost gold and create a spillover benefit for silver. The Eurozone crisis also helped boost volumes in the US, but of greater importance was trend following into silver's rally; this had seen the price shoot up from a low of just $8.46 in 2008 to a record high in 2011 of $49.79.

Disappointment at silver's inability to break through $50 and the subsequent retreat initially fed to notably weaker demand, but renewed concerns over QE brought about a late-2012 recovery. This largely set the tone for the next three years as ongoing, but changing worries about financial markets and periods of bargain hunting and profit taking kept demand high if lacking direction at an average of 115Moz (3,577t) over 2013-16 (which included 2015's then record of 124.8Moz (3,882t)).

The lull – 2017 to 2019

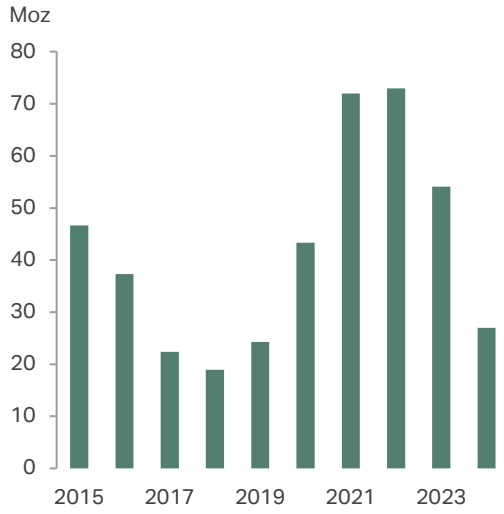
This changed markedly in the period 2017-19, when net demand fell to an average of just 50.4Moz (1,568t). Some of the drop was price related as subdued levels saw investor enthusiasm falter. At the same time, silver faced mounting pressure from equities; from the beginning of 2017 to the end of 2019, the S&P rose by a stellar 43% while silver managed just 13% (and that included a dip below $14 in 2018). There was also a belief among committed Republicans that with Trump in the White House there was less need for defensive investments. Lastly, there was a strong element of market saturation; with almost 800Moz (24,883t) having been purchased in the seven years up to 2016, dealers often reported that retail investors had satisfied their needs.

The robust rebound – 2020 to 2023

This all changed in 2020 as demand boomed to 94.3Moz (2,933t). This was largely due to the hunt for safe havens as the COVID crisis struck. This was largely gold-centered, but silver ultimately benefited, in part as volumes were boosted by bargain hunting (the price had dipped to just $11.64 in March as some feared industrial demand would implode) and then trend following (the price almost reached $30 in early August that year). Another driver was a coin shortage. This became exacerbated in 2020 as production and distribution problems linked directly to the epidemic meant many investors rushed to buy whatever they could lay their hands on. Understandably, this caused premiums to rocket to unprecedented levels, especially for Eagles. This fed through to a market share shift to other sovereign and private mints and to a jump for bars, a growing percentage of which had to be imported.

These forces largely remained in play in 2021, but were joined in dramatic fashion early on by a frenzy of buying linked to social media campaigns on the Reddit platform, striving to force the price higher in a manner similar

US Retail Bar Demand



Source: Metals Focus

to the successful targeting of Gamestop shares. While more considered investors might have stayed away from this hailstorm, they may well have been motived by inflation concerns linked to high levels of borrowing by a Democrat administration. As a result and with selling back by investors trivial, net demand in 2021 posted a fresh record high of 138.2Moz (4,299t).

Volumes then only eased a fraction in 2022 as demand was sustained by ongoing inflation concerns and Russia's invasion of Ukraine. Geopolitics remained to the fore the following year with the Hamas attacks on Israel in October, but 2023 had already seen a new factor emerge in the form of two US bank failures (Silicon Valley Bank and Signature Bank), which fed through to a busy period from March to May. Despite the outbreak of hostilities in the Middle East, profit taking began to pick up in the second half of 2023 and this was reinforced by cost-of-living issues linked to high inflation and the ending of federal support programs. All this plus an element of market saturation explains the slight pullback in volumes to a still high level of 120.8Moz (3,757t) that year.

One aspect sustaining volumes at over the 100Moz (3,110t) level in this period was the rapid and semi-structural growth in silver going into IRAs. This is a 'useful' form of investment as, to date, it has very much been a one-way trade, with silver very rarely leaving a custodian's vault – so far, if a retiree needs to sell, there has always been another saver waiting in the wings to buy up the metal and forestall release into the broader market. (Silver-containing IRAs were first made legal in 1986, but volumes only became meaningful during the 1990s before growing massively from the mid-2000s onwards.)

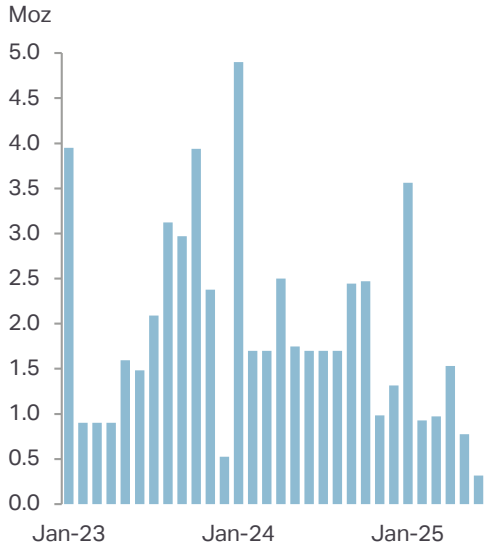
2024 Review

Last year, US silver retail investment fell by a notable 46% to 64.9Moz (2,020t) and so closer to levels seen in the 2017-19 lull. Those factors that drove the modest retreat in the second half of 2023 (such as the large volume of earlier purchases) remained relevant and were joined by greater profit taking with prices north of $30 and an element of crisis fatigue.

A notable feature saw gross purchases of bars and coins turn soft and liquidations remain relatively high. Many dealers feel that a good number of investors in precious metals tend to be Republican-leaning and so expectations of a 'better' management of the US under Trump's second administration also curtailed demand.

It is worth noting that investor liquidations of silver holdings are not only rare for IRAs but for most forms of bars and coins. To an extent, this is fueled by a currently widespread belief that silver is undervalued and so it would unwise to sell now. Secondly, those that have bought silver defensively have had as yet no real cause to sell. Finally, the absence of a domestic crisis (like the regional banking closures of 2023) significantly impacted safe-haven demand.

US Eagle Bullion Coin Sales



Source: US Mint

The above noted weakness may not seem supported by silver Eagle sales by the US Mint, which for the full year were just 2% lower y/y. However, that reflects an uplift in their market share, chiefly as production challenges for the Mint have eased.

2025 Outlook

We forecast that retail investment in the US will decline further this year, by 29% to a multi-decade low of 45.9Moz (1,427t). In so doing, it will echo the depressed levels that characterized the 2017-19 period. In addition to there being a full year of a Republican administration, many of the above-mentioned headwinds are likely to remain in force and we have assumed that no fresh major crises erupt.

However, we should see a slight improvement in the second half. That largely depends on the silver price, which is forecast to see further gains before year-end. This should prompt both profit taking and also encourage trend following by those looking for silver to approach 2011's record high. As such, two-way trading should ramp-up. This will benefit coin and bar dealers, who see both sides of the market. However, those supplying newly struck coins and bars may see very little benefit from this dynamic.

One note of caution exists in the form of the ongoing uncertainty about the Trump administration's tariff policies, and what this means for US inflation and growth. Another area of uncertainty relates to the US administration's stance towards the US Federal Reserve's Chairman, Jerome Powell. A new Chairman is due to take up their post in May 2026. However, growing disquiet towards Powell could increase the prospects of his term ending prematurely. Such an outcome would likely weigh on the dollar, to the benefit of silver (and gold) prices. It would also boost safe haven demand for precious metals, including silver bars and coins.

Chapter 3

India

Introduction

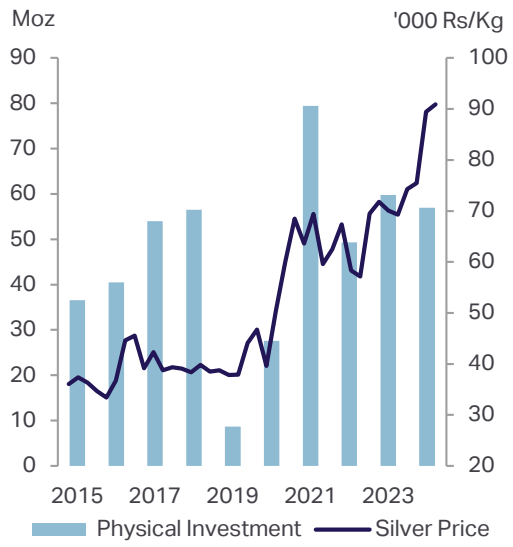
Since gaining independence in 1947, India's economy has undergone a significant transformation, with liberalization in 1991 marking a major turning point. While the country has since seen robust economic growth and rising incomes, access to formal banking and financial services remained limited for much of this period, especially in rural and semi-urban areas. This allowed gold and silver to emerge as traditional savings vehicles. They also served as collateral for informal lending and as a means of storing unaccounted wealth.

Historically, a low banking penetration meant many borrowers relied on informal funding channels, where gold and silver often acted as an essential collateral. Nonetheless, government initiatives such as the Jan Dhan Yojana, launched in August 2014, have significantly improved financial inclusion. This initiative was aimed at people who were previously excluded from the formal banking system. As of July 2nd 2025, over 550m Jan Dhan accounts have been opened since 2014, marking significant progress for the financial industry.

Although gold has long been more deeply financialized, silver is also gradually catching up as investor awareness improves. Being more affordable makes silver attractive for tactical, short-term investors, both in physical form and through futures. The launch of silver exchange-traded products (ETPs) in 2022 further widened access to silver. Meanwhile, digital silver remains nascent, with limited uptake having so far occurred.

Retail investment stood at just 25.7Moz (800t) in 2010. However, it grew rapidly on the back of rising domestic silver prices. Although these peaked at Rs.73,600/kg in 2011, investor interest remained positive. A gradual decline in prices triggered sharply higher buying interest, taking demand to an all-time high of 110.4Moz (3,435t) in 2015. As prices bottomed out that year and subsequently began to rise, demand started to ease. Despite this, investors have bought over 514Moz (16,000t) of silver bars and coins over the last 10 years. In 2024, demand stood at 59.8Moz (1,859t), accounting for 30% of global retail investment — its highest share since 2019. Silver bars remained the most popular form among retail investors, comprising over 70% of total demand last year.

Indian Silver Physical Investment



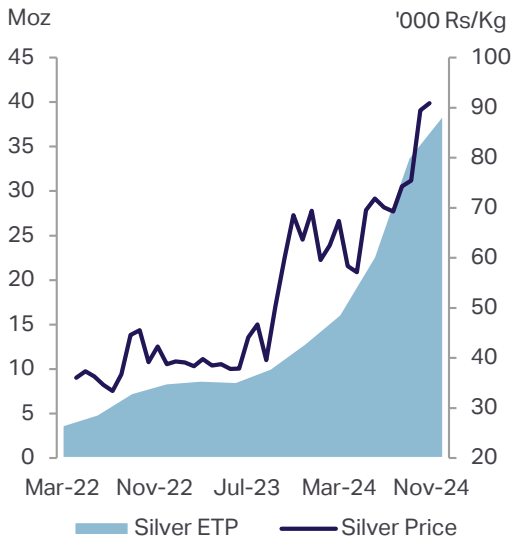
Source: Metals Focus, Bloomberg

The Structure of the Indian Silver Investment Market

Physical investment and its rival forms

The most prominent alternative investment vehicle for silver are ETPs. These are traded on the National Stock Exchange (NSE) and Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE), backed by silver stored in custodian vaults, with an annual fee of below 0.5%.

Indian Silver ETP Holdings



Source: Individual Company reports, Metals Focus

In addition to ETPs, investors can also gain exposure to silver through fund-of-funds (FoFs). These are set up by mutual funds who, in turn, invest in ETPs. FoFs offer certain advantages over ETPs, such as allowing investors to participate without the need for a trading account, which is a key requirement for investing in ETPs. Additionally, FoFs enable systematic investment plans (SIPs), making it easier for investors to gradually allocate funds over a period of time.

The launch of silver ETPs in India in 2022 has significantly reshaped the investment landscape. In roughly three years, their holdings have surged from just 2.1Moz (65t) in Q1.22 to over 38Moz (1,183t) by Q4.24, reflecting a compounded annual growth rate (CAGR) of over 200%. To put this into perspective, silver ETPs saw inflows of approximately 25.1Moz (782t) in 2024, equivalent to 44% of the country's physical investment for that year. As we write (in July), holdings have now surpassed 58Moz (1,800t).

To provide some perspective, gold ETPs have struggled to attract similar levels of investor interest in India. Despite a recent uptick in holdings, gold ETPs have accumulated just over 2Moz (64t) since their introduction in 2007. In 2024, gold ETPs saw an inflow of 0.5Moz (15t), which is just 6% of India's retail investment last year, of 7.7Moz (239t).

Several factors are contributing to the growing interest in silver ETPs. First, silver's inherent price volatility, coupled with a positive price outlook among many Indian investors, makes it an attractive tactical investment for those seeking potential gains. Historically, concerns about the challenges of storing large quantities of silver deterred some investors, but the convenience and liquidity of silver ETPs have removed this barrier. Additionally, rising financial awareness has played a significant role in the rapid expansion of this segment. India has also witnessed a sharp increase in retail trading accounts, with the total number soaring from 41m in March 2020 to 185m by December 2024. Notably, in 2023 and 2024 alone, 77m new accounts were added.

Some companies are also offering digital silver products. This is an emerging option that allows individuals to buy, sell, and hold silver online without the need for physical storage. It operates through various fintech or payment platforms, such as Google Pay, PhonePe and jeweler/refineries' in-house applications, enabling investors to purchase silver in fractional amounts, for as little as Re.1. When a purchase is made, the equivalent quantity of physical silver is acquired and held in vaults managed by third-party custodians.

One of the advantages of digital silver is its high liquidity. Investors can sell their holdings at prevailing market rates at any time through the same platform, offering far greater flexibility compared to traditional physical silver. For example, while silver ETPs can only be traded during market hours, digital silver is not subject to such constraints, allowing transactions to be executed around the clock. Some platforms also provide the option to convert digital holdings into physical silver, subject

to minimum quantity requirements. While digital silver offers convenience and accessibility, it does come with certain costs, such as storage fees, goods and services tax (GST), and transaction charges, which vary across platforms. Additionally, wide buy-sell spreads and a lack of regulatory oversight remain a significant barrier to growth for this segment. However, leading providers are looking to build credibility by partnering with reputable refiners and secure vaulting companies.

Exchange trading has also picked up in recent years in India on the Multi Commodity Exchange of India (MCX), which was established in 2003 and has since become India's largest commodity derivatives exchange. Over the years, the MCX has expanded its offerings to include three silver contracts, the 30kg "Silver", 5kg "Silver Mini" and 1kg "Silver Micro", catering to different segments of investors. These contracts also differ in terms of margin requirements, allowing both retail and institutional investors to participate in the silver market. Additionally, it is important to distinguish whether these contracts belong to futures or options products.

The main silver futures contract, which accounted for 34% of total silver turnover across all three contracts in 2024, has grown at an average rate of 20% per annum since its inception in 2003, reaching its highest turnover in 2011 of 49%. While actual delivery volumes are trivial (typically less than 1% for any given contract), they have provided an important avenue for investors, speculators, and the trade to participate in silver price rallies.

Some investors also capitalize on the price differential between the spot and futures markets by buying silver in the spot market and simultaneously selling futures on the exchange. This arbitrage typically generates annual yields of 5-10%, according to our estimates.

MCX silver contracts started to gain momentum after the 2008 global financial crisis, with turnover rising by an average of 32% over the next three years. In 2011, as silver prices soared, combined trading volumes on the MCX for all these silver contracts touched 118m contracts. Between 2009 and 2013, futures contracts were especially popular as they provided investors the opportunity to gain from the silver price rally by committing a small margin (around 5%) compared to the 100% capital outlay required to invest in physical metal.

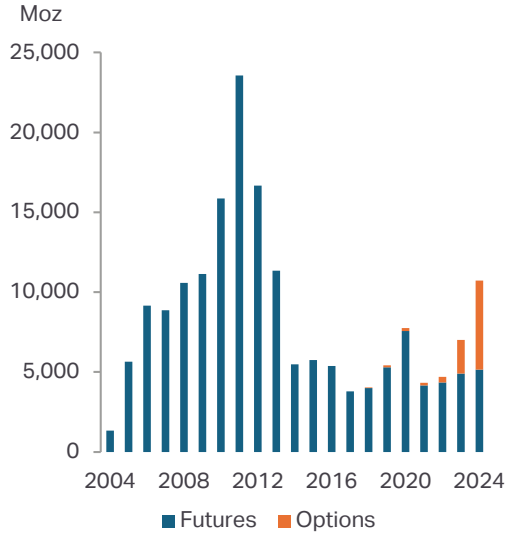
Despite reaching record levels in 2011 of 23,568Moz (733,036t), futures trading volumes have declined significantly, as the sharp drop in silver prices caused widespread losses for retail investors and traders. Investors became more aware of the risks of margin trading, with those with a

Indian Silver Futures and Options Contracts

Contract	Lot Size	Available Instruments	Users
Standard	30 kg	Futures & Options	Institutions, large traders, refiners
Mini	5 kg	Futures & Options	Retail speculators, small-scale jewelers
Micro	1 kg	Futures only	Individual investors

Source: Multi Commodity Exchange

MCX Silver Main Contract Turnover



Source: Multi Commodity Exchange

genuine interest to invest in silver typically preferred to do so through bars and coins.

Exchange activity has improved over the last couple of years, with the pandemic impacting physical purchases and with precious metals witnessing renewed investor interest. Even so, in 2024, the volume of futures traded, at 5,157Moz (169,390t), remaining 80% below its peak.

While futures volumes have suffered, the introduction of options on silver futures has helped lift volumes on the exchanges in the last two to three years. To provide some backdrop, options contracts on the silver 30kg contract were introduced in 2018 and, in 2021, on the silver mini (5kg) contract. While the initial response was relatively subdued, due to muted silver prices, limited hedging demand, low trading activity, and high margins, volumes have since picked up noticeably. As a result, in 2024, the volume of 30kg silver options contracts exceeded that of futures for the first time since their inception in 2018, growing at an annual rate of 170%.

As silver mini contracts continue to accommodate smaller participants because of their small 5kg lot size, they have achieved a 50% annual increase in turnover since 2005. Volatile silver prices have further encouraged traders to shift towards option mini contracts due to their lower capital requirements and reduced risk exposure. Since the launch of mini options in 2021, the market has rapidly transitioned to this product, which has accounted for 40% of total silver mini turnover in just four years.

Turning to silver micro contracts (1kg), which were introduced in 2011, these have experienced an annual growth rate of 10% since their inception, thanks to robust growth in 2020 when pandemic-driven price swings attracted bargain hunters and hedgers. However, in 2024, their turnover declined by 11%, which reflected a lack of options contracts, low liquidity, and traders shifting to silver mini options contracts as they require less upfront capital (only the premium), leaving micro lots as a niche for very small-scale, direct-exposure players.

Silver versus other precious metals

In India, investing in silver bars and coins has gained in popularity as an affordable alternative to gold. Silver is widely used in the jewelry and silverware segments, which creates consistent demand alongside its role as an investment asset.

Silver bars and coins are available through jewelers, bullion dealers, and refiners, with options ranging from small coins (as low as 1g) to larger investment-grade bars (1kg or more). While silver benefits from its cultural and religious significance, it is also attractive due to its tactical appeal. That said, one of the key challenges of investing in silver in India is storage. Additionally, investors may encounter liquidity challenges when reselling smaller coins, which often carry higher premiums compared with gold. While major cities have active bullion markets, rural and semi-urban areas may have fewer resale options, potentially leading to lower buyback prices.

Sales of Minted Silver Products

Denomination	Market Share Estimates
5-10g	10%
50-100g	60-70%
250-500g	10%
1kg	5%
5kg	5%

Source: Metals Focus

The product structure of Indian physical investment in silver

Jewelry shops account for 80-85% of silver bar and coin retail sales in India. However, due to slim profit margins and high inventory costs, over the years jewelers have scaled back their promotional activities. Instead, they keep bars and coins as a part of their inventory and typically only sell them upon request. Consequently, there has been a gradual shift towards e-commerce platforms, like Flipkart and Amazon for consumer purchases. Refineries also offer direct sales through their websites. Even so jewelers still dominate this market given their extensive retail presence.

Within physical investment, there are essentially two types of investors: small and high net worth (HNW)/institutional investors. The former tend to buy bars between 250g and 1kg, which account for about 60-70% of the market. HNW investors tend to prefer 5kg to 30kg bars.

Most bars are of 999s purity. Some investors prefer non-standardized bars as they are relatively inexpensive. Many investors who look to buy bars of between 1kg-15kg often receive a Chausa (pieces cut from a 30kg bar).

Looking at silver coin demand in India this is driven by two main factors, gifting and religious purposes. Roughly 30-40% of sales occur around Diwali, Dhanteras,and Akshaya Tritiya. These coins often feature religious inscriptions, including images of deities such as Laxmi, Ganesha, and Shri Ram. Popular coin denominations are 5g, 10g, 20g, 25g and 50g.

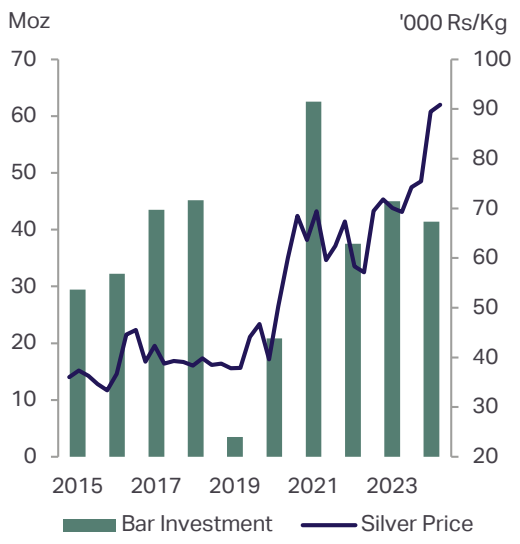
Beyond religious themes, silver coins are also designed for festive gifting, such as Raksha Bandhan, symbolizing the sibling bond, or special occasions like Mother's Day. Manufacturers continue to innovate by introducing products around trending themes. For example, many jewelers now offer coins featuring the Ayodhya Ram Mandir, following its recent inauguration. Some refineries have also partnered with brands like Disney and Marvel Studios to create silver coins engraved with popular characters, appealing to a younger audience.

One interesting aspect of the silver retail investment market is the increase in the market share of coins at the expense of bars from 4% in 2010 to 25% in 2024. This reflects increased gifting demand due to rising incomes, which has seen coin sales grow from just 1Moz (30t) in 2010 to 14.8Moz (459t) in 2024 (after a high of 16.8Moz, 524t, in 2022).

Characteristics of Indian investors

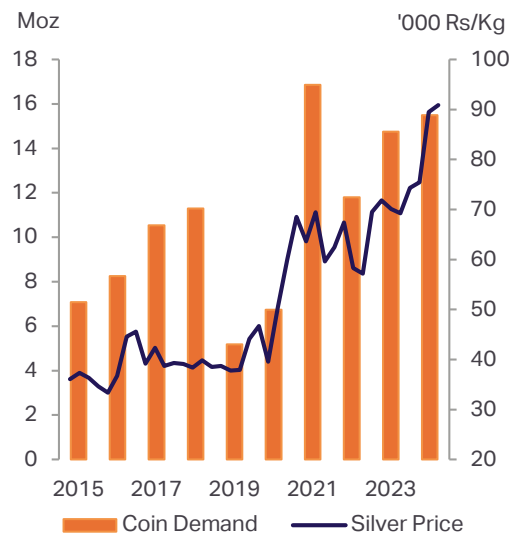
The composition of silver retail coin and bar investors in India is distinct from that of gold investors, shaped by economic factors, cultural traditions, and affordability. Many of these investors belong to the middle class or lower-income groups, for whom silver provides an accessible entry point into the precious metals market. It allows people to accumulate small quantities over time, making it a preferred choice for those looking to hedge against inflation and economic uncertainties without requiring a large initial investment.

Silver Bar Demand



Source: Metals Focus, Bloomberg

Silver Coin Demand



Source: Metals Focus, Bloomberg

In India, silver is not only seen as an investment asset but also holds cultural significance, particularly during festivals like Diwali and Dhanteras, when buying precious metals is considered auspicious. Silver bars and coins are also often gifted at weddings and other celebrations, leading to seasonal spikes in demand. Although banking penetration has increased, rural buyers, especially farmers and small business owners, still prefer holding physical silver as a store of value, as it offers a sense of security.

Unlike urban investors, who may consider silver ETPs or digital products, most retail buyers in India prefer physical silver, believing in the security of a tangible asset. However, this preference comes with challenges, as silver requires more space compared to gold for the same investment value.

Price sensitivity is another characteristic of retail silver investors in India. Buyers tend to enter the market when silver prices are low, accumulating holdings gradually rather than making bulk purchases. However, resale liquidity remains a challenge, as the secondary market for silver is less developed compared with gold. While jewelers and bullion dealers do offer buyback options, resale prices can vary significantly, with small investors often facing lower returns due to purity concerns and wide dealer margins.

A unique aspect of silver investment in India is that manufacturers, particularly those in the jewelry and silverware segments, often hoard silver as a form of investment. Unlike in other markets, where silver is primarily a raw material for production, Indian manufacturers view silver not just as an input but also as a financial asset. This practice is driven by the metal's price volatility and the need to hedge against future cost increases. Many jewelry and silverware hubs, especially in cities like Agra, Ahmedabad and Jaipur, stockpile silver when prices are low, ensuring both a steady supply for production and potential profits from price appreciation.

Product premiums for bars and coins

In India, silver bars and coins come with a premium over the prevailing spot price, influenced by factors such as purity, weight, brand reputation, and supply chain costs. These premiums typically range between 10%-50%, depending on the product and seller.

Bars:

Investment-grade silver bars, particularly those weighing 500g to 1kg, usually attract lower premiums compared to smaller bars and coins. Standard 1kg silver bars from reputed refiners generally carry a 15-20% premium. Bulk buyers often negotiate lower premiums, especially for wholesale transactions.

Coins:

Silver coins feature higher premiums, especially for smaller denominations like 10g, 50g, and 100g. Premiums on silver coins typically range from 40-50%, with special edition or commemorative coins commanding higher prices.

Average Retail Premiums

Denomination	Coins	Bars
10g	40-50%	NA
20g	30-40%	NA
50g	20-25%	NA
100g	10-15%	NA
250g	NA	10-15%
1kg	NA	10-15%

Source: Metals Focus

Branded silver products from recognized refiners carry higher premiums due to purity guarantees, tamper-proof packaging, and a better resale value. Locally minted or unbranded silver bars and coins are available at lower premiums but may face challenges during resale due to concerns over purity and authenticity. Retail margins (or making charges) range between 10-50%, depending on the bar size and the seller.

Long-Term Trends

A review of Indian retail investment since 2010 (the start of Metals Focus' series) reveals three distinct phases: a period of strong growth until 2015; a sharp correction in silver prices accompanied by lower investment demand until 2020, and finally, a recovery with renewed interest.

Demand for silver bars and coins in India has exhibited significant fluctuations, influenced by factors such as economic conditions, metal prices, investment sentiment, and market uncertainty. While silver bar demand has been more volatile, silver coin demand has demonstrated relatively steady growth, particularly in recent years.

2010 to 2015 - Period of Strong Growth

From 2010 to 2015, demand for silver bars surged, rising from 24.8Moz (770t) to 103.2Moz (3,211t). This reflected growing investment interest in silver, driven by global economic uncertainties after the 2008 financial crisis and the subsequent rise in spot prices. Local prices jumped nearly three-fold during that period before correcting significantly by 2015. The silver market also benefited from a weak Indian rupee, pushing more investors to seek the safe-haven offered by precious metals, particularly silver, as investors sought silver as an alternative to gold, given its affordability.

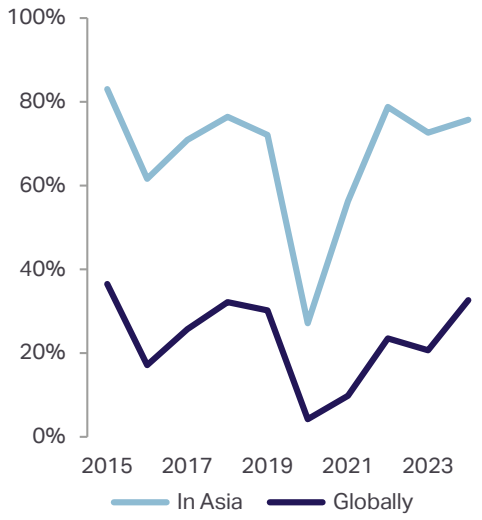
During the same period, silver coin demand followed a broadly consistent upward trajectory, increasing from 1Moz (30t) in 2010 to 7.2Moz (224t) in 2015. This was driven by increasing retail participation, growing awareness about silver as a long-term investment and the cultural preference for gifting silver coins during festivals and weddings.

2016 to 2020 - Sharp Decline and Market Corrections

Following the 2015 peak, silver bar demand experienced a sharp decline, dropping to just 29.5Moz (916t) in 2016. During this period, domestic silver prices traded around Rs30,000s/kg, a substantial fall from the peak seen in 2013. Prices fell to just Rs.33,500 during COVID in March 2020. This resulted in waning investor confidence, resulting in profit taking by investors. In addition, shifting investment preferences towards equity and real estate markets led to weak demand for bars and coins. A similar trend continued in subsequent years, with bar demand hovering at around 30-45Moz (1,000–1,400t) between 2017 and 2019.

Silver coin demand, however, remained relatively stable, even when the market corrected. It reached 11.3Moz (352t) in 2019 from just 1Moz (30t)

Indian Share of Asian and World Physical Silver Investment



Source: Metals Focus

in 2010, reflecting a steady increase in retail investors who continued to accumulate silver despite broader investment shifts. The broad stability of coin demand suggests that small investors and traditional buyers maintained their interest in silver, even as larger investors moved away from bars.

2020 marked an extreme low in silver bar demand, of just 3.5Moz (108t). This was largely due to the pandemic, which disrupted supply chains, reduced discretionary spending, and created significant economic uncertainty. Moreover, we saw a heavy sell-off in the local market as domestic silver prices surpassed their 2011 highs in 2020, which led to investors exiting their positions. Demand for silver coins also dropped to 5.2Moz (161t), though the slide was not as pronounced as for bars, indicating that small investors still engaged in silver purchases despite the challenging economic climate.

2021 to 2024 - Recovery and Renewed Interest

It is important to note that the 2011 highs made by silver prices, of Rs.73,600/kg, were only eclipsed in 2020. This generated sizable liquidations despite inflation-adjusted returns remaining negative. However, after peaking at Rs.78,000/kg in 2020, prices consolidated for a while followed by a correction to Rs.51,850 by September 2022, which led to bargain hunting. Investors bought 79.4Moz (2,470t) of bars and coins that year, the highest total since 2015. That was also a year of record silver bullion imports, which reached 305.8Moz (9,511t).

After bottoming out in 2022, prices quickly strengthened, touching Rs100,000/kg in October 2024 for the first time ever. While investment demand was lower compared to 2022, it remained healthy as some buying shifted to ETPs. Moreover, despite record high prices, investor confidence in silver has strengthened.

2024 Review

We estimate that retail investment grew by 21% y/y to 59.8Moz (1,859t) in 2024. Within this, bar demand rose by 20% to 45Moz (1,401t), while coin purchases saw a sharper increase to 14.8Moz (459t); up 25% y/y and the second highest in our series. This performance was driven by attractive local prices. Prices started trending upwards in February last year before peaking at Rs.96,500/kg in May. Many investors who were waiting on the sidelines could not enter the market given the rapid price gains.

However, in a surprise move, the Indian government reduced the import duty on gold and silver from 15% to 6% on July 23rd. This resulted in the domestic prices falling immediately by 6-7%, and so providing an opportunity for investors to enter the market at lower rates (the duty is embedded in the local price which is referred to as the “landed price”). Thereafter, local prices weakened further as international prices also declined, touching a low of Rs.78,270 in August, which resulted in bargain hunting.

However, the correction was short-lived. Within three months of the duty cut, the domestic silver price had surged to a record high of Rs.100,000. This rally bolstered investor confidence, with demand remaining strong even at these elevated prices. The price upside also coincided with Diwali—an auspicious period to buy metal—which saw robust demand despite record high prices.

2025 Outlook

Given near record prices, we forecast that bar demand will decline by 8% y/y this year, while coin demand is expected to continue rising, by 5%. Overall, demand is projected to fall by 5%. Unlike 2024, when higher prices helped generate demand for bars and coins, we expect to see liquidations in 2025 as prices rise from already elevated levels.

As mentioned earlier, Indian investors have already acquired over 835.9Moz (26,000t) of metal since 2010. We expect this to slowly come out as investors typically look at silver more from a tactical perspective than a strategic one as in the case of gold. Additionally, growing awareness and adoption of ETPs could further weigh on retail investment, as investors increasingly turn to these instruments. This year alone, ETP holdings are expected to grow by 20–25Moz (600-800t), reflecting continued investor interest.

Additionally, in terms of activity on the exchange, options turnover has already reached 72% of 2024's full-year volume in the first half of 2025, underscoring a shift toward these contracts, particularly the silver mini variant. We expect this shift to continue in 2025 as participants transition to lower-denomination contracts.

Chapter 4

Germany

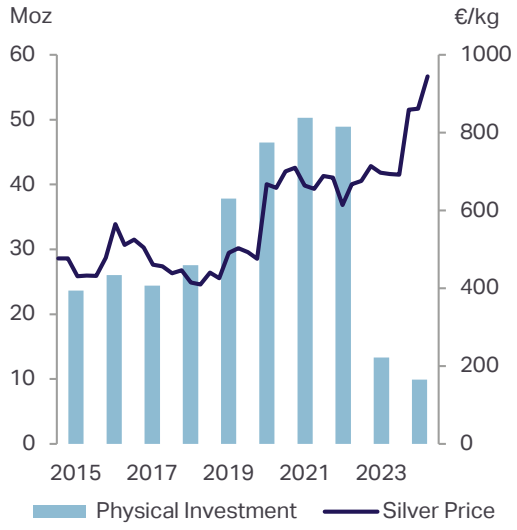
Introduction

Germany is the largest market for physical silver investment in Europe. Globally, excluding 2024, it ranked as the third-largest each year since 2010. Cumulatively, Germany recorded net purchases of a substantial 448.5Moz (13,950t) over 2010-24, accounting for 13% of global demand.

This strong investor interest reflects a deep-rooted cultural affinity for gold and silver among the German public. This tradition stems from historical experiences of hyperinflation and currency debasement in the 1920s and the aftermath of the Second World War. As a result, Germans have developed a strong commitment to sound money and high personal savings rates. Naturally, events such as the collapse of Lehman Brothers, the European sovereign debt crisis, the COVID-19 pandemic, and the invasion of Ukraine have all, at various times, driven heightened demand for safe-haven assets like physical silver (and gold). In addition, monetary policy, the economic outlook, price expectations, and competition from other asset classes have also influenced investor appetite for silver.

Value-added tax (VAT) is another critical factor that helps to understand the German market. Compared to other countries covered in this report, German retail investors face significantly higher taxes when purchasing physical silver. Furthermore, the VAT regime on silver bullion products has undergone two changes since 2014. Each time, these adjustments created uncertainty at the wholesale and retail level, and led to shifts in the product mix of coins and bars bought by retail investors, as well as the absolute volume of each one.

German Silver Physical Investment



Source: Metals Focus, Bloomberg

German Investment Market Structure

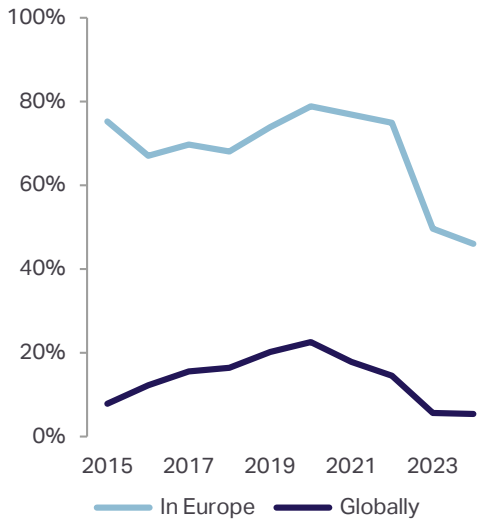
VAT and regulations landscape

VAT has long been a key challenge for the German physical silver market. Currently, sales of silver bars and bullion coins are subject to 19% VAT. This presents a significant disadvantage compared to other markets discussed in this report, where silver investment products are either exempt from sales tax, or subject to low single-digit rates.

As illustrated in the table on the following page, the VAT regime in Germany has undergone two major changes affecting silver bullion product sales. Prior to 2014, silver bullion coins and coinbars were subject to 7% VAT on their full value, significantly lower than the 19% applicable to bars. While still higher than in most other key retail silver investment markets, these rates were among the lowest in the EU, where silver coins and bars are typically taxed equally at around 20%. This disparity with neighboring EU countries and the principle of VAT harmonization is believed to be a key reason behind the VAT changes introduced in 2014.

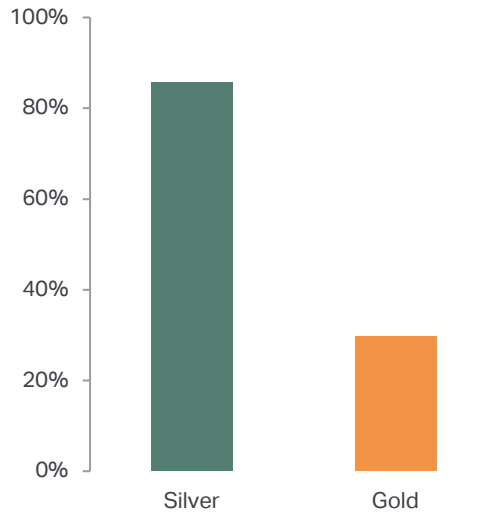
At the beginning of 2014, VAT on silver coins in Germany was raised to 19%, aligning with the rate applied to bars. However, existing laws allowed

German Share of European and World Physical Silver Investment



Source: Metals Focus

Coins' Share in Germany over 2015-24



Source: Metals Focus

Timeline of VAT Changes to Silver Bullion Products

Effective Date	Bars	EU Bullion Coins/ Coinbars	Non-EU Bullion Coins/Coinbars
Prior to 2014	19% of full value	7% of full value	7% of full value
Jan 1st 2014	19% of full value	19% of full value	7% of the full value plus 19% of dealers' margin
Jan 1st 2023	19% of full value	19% of full value	19% of full value

bullion traders to use a margin tax regime to mitigate the impact. For non-EU coins and coinbars, the 19% VAT was only applied to the dealer's margin, in addition to the 7% on the full product value. The impact of the new tax regime on non-EU coins was minimal, resulting in little change in investor sentiment. By contrast, the margin tax could not be applied to EU coins, which have been subject to 19% VAT on the full value since 2014 (the margin tax still applies to secondary market coins).

In September 2022, the German government announced an abrupt end to this favorable VAT treatment for non-EU products. The original plan was for the change to take immediate effect, but the deadline was later extended to the beginning of 2023. Investor sentiment took a hit following the change, as evidenced by a collapse in silver retail investment that year.

Another key factor influencing investor decisions in precious metals was the limit on anonymous cash transactions. From €15,000 in 2010, the threshold for these purchases (not requiring customer identification) was reduced to €10,000 in 2017 and then to just €2,000 in 2020. These changes had the most pronounced impact on gold, particularly due to its exceptional price rally in recent years. With the exception of late 2019 (when investors rushed to buy gold ahead of the limit change, which also spilled over to silver), the current limit has had little, if any, impact on purchases of silver bullion products.

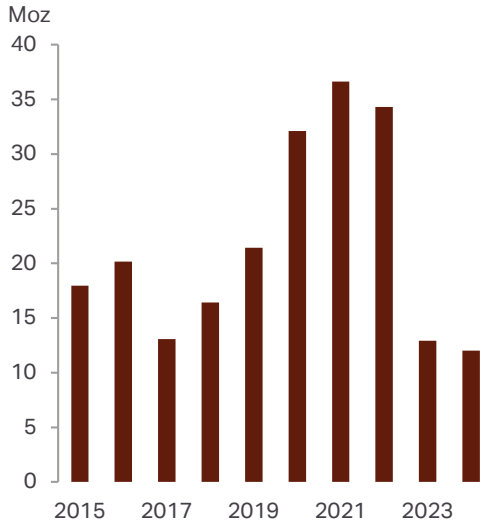
Product availability and distribution

Bullion Coins

Due to a more favorable VAT treatment, the German physical silver market has long been dominated by bullion coins. Metals Focus estimates that sales of bullion coins averaged 24.4Moz (759t) per annum over 2010-24, accounting for roughly 80% of the total market. This contrasts sharply with gold, where bars dominate due to their lower premiums.

Given the scale of German coin demand, most key mints and refineries have enjoyed strong sales in the country, with 1oz coins being by far the most popular. Historically, these have included the Austrian Mint's Philharmoniker, the Perth Mint's Kookaburra, China Gold Coin's Panda, the Royal Canadian Mint's Maple Leaf, the UK's Royal Mint Britannia, and the US Mint's Eagle. In 2017, the Rand Refinery launched its 1oz silver Krugerrand bullion coin, capitalizing on Germany's historical affinity for gold Krugerrands. In terms of investor preferences, no single silver coin has

Primary Silver Bullion Coin Sales in Europe by Major Mints



Source: Metals Focus

consistently led the market. Metals Focus' quarterly bullion coin survey shows that the share of individual coins has varied significantly over the years, depending on product availability, premiums, and VAT rates.

Coinbars

Although shaped like bars, coinbars are considered coins because they feature an image of a coin with a nominal face value. These products also have legal tender status and were therefore eligible for margin tax treatment until 2023. Coinbars are available in various sizes, with heavier pieces, such as 1kg, attracting more investor interest due to their favorable tax treatment. Unsurprisingly, demand for these products has declined following 2023's VAT change.

Bars

Due to the VAT disadvantage, bars have historically accounted for a small market share. Among those investors interested in bars, there is a strong preference for German brands, although foreign products, mainly those produced by Swiss refineries, are also well recognized. Silver investment bars are available in a wide range of weights, from 1g to 15kg. For retail investors, 1oz, 100g, and 1kg bars tend to be the most popular. In recent years, products like Valcambi's CombiBars and HM Precious Metals' UnityBars have gained in popularity, as they offer the flexibility of being sold as a combination of individual small silver bars (such as 100×1g) that can be separated at a later date.

Larger investment bars are typically bought by high-net-worth investors and family offices. These bars, typically in 15kg units, are stored in bonded warehouses to benefit from VAT-free status. It is important to note that this type of investment is considered institutional activity in the over-the-counter market. Our estimate of net physical investment only captures retail investor activity, which extends to bullion coins and small bars.

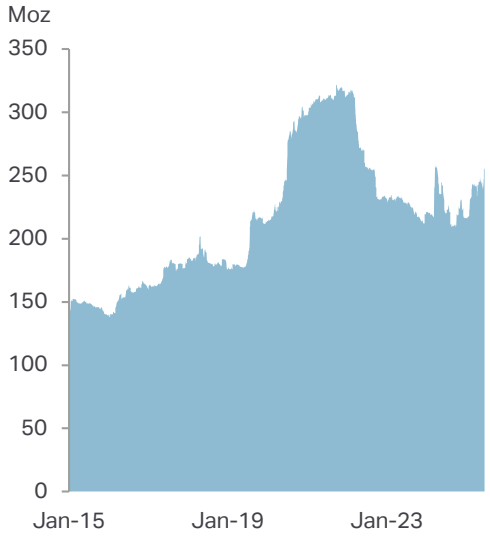
Numismatic and commemorative coins

Germany also benefits from healthy sales of commemorative coins. Among these, German euro coins are popular with local collectors. The original €10 collector coin was made of a sterling silver alloy consisting of 92.5% silver and 7.5% copper until 2010. Due to rising silver prices, the silver content was reduced to 62.5% in 2011. Starting in 2016, the €10 collector coin was reissued as a €20 version, which returned to the original composition of 92.5% silver and 7.5% copper.

Distribution

Germany boasts a robust retail infrastructure for bullion products. Bullion bars and coins are available through public sector bank branches, including local savings banks (Sparkassen) and regional institutions (Landesbanken). Private bullion dealers also play a key role, with major players operating shops across the country. Numerous, smaller dealers focus on local demand or operate online platforms. This well-established infrastructure ensures that both the sale and buyback of bullion products are offered at competitive rates in Germany.

European Silver ETPs



Source: Bloomberg, Metals Focus

Physical investment and its rival forms

In addition to direct purchases of bars and coins, retail investors can invest in silver through other vehicles. As discussed below, many of these products offer distinct advantages, such as favorable VAT treatment (provided investors do not take physical delivery), lower transaction fees or premiums, and leveraged exposure to silver price movements. However, feedback from German contacts suggests that most retail investors still prefer physical ownership of precious metals, as wealth protection remains the primary motivation behind these purchases.

A very different picture emerges when we look at institutional investors, for whom the cost of buying and holding metal significantly influences investment decisions. For example, family offices and high-net-worth individuals typically prefer to store physical silver in Swiss bonded warehouses, which are exempt from VAT.

Exchange Traded Products (ETPs)

Several physically backed silver ETPs are traded on Xetra in Germany, a trading venue operated by the Deutsche Börse Group. These include products offered by WisdomTree, Xtrackers, and Invesco. Key advantages of these ETPs include safety, transparency, liquidity, and ease of access. Investment in silver ETPs is also tax-efficient, as purchases made on stock exchanges are VAT-exempt. VAT only applies if holders request physical delivery of the metal.

As these products tend to be listed on several European exchanges, it is difficult to estimate the precise share held by German investors. At the end of 2024, total holdings in European-listed ETPs amounted to 216.4Moz (6,731t). While this is a substantial figure, it is still dwarfed by the size of silver ETPs held in North America.

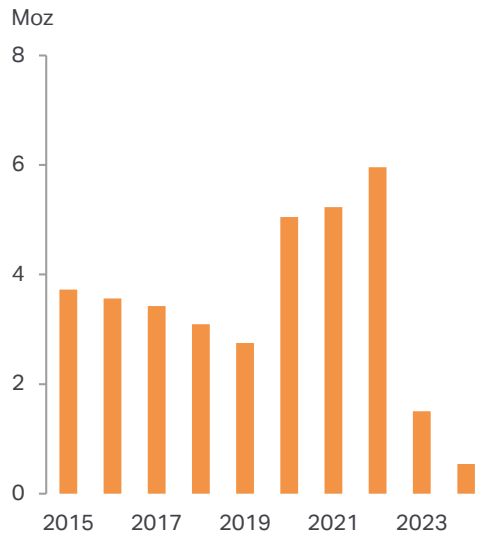
Silver savings plans

Precious metal savings plans allow investors to make regular purchases, typically with small amounts. By making periodic payments, investors can mitigate the impact of price fluctuations. For savers with limited budgets, this scheme enables them to gradually accumulate precious metal holdings over time. Once a certain amount of silver has been accumulated, investors can request physical delivery, though VAT will be applied at that point. Historically, these savings plans in Germany were offered by private bullion dealers. In recent years, a growing number of German savings banks have introduced such products, significantly boosting investor interest thanks to their broader client networks.

Bonded warehouse storage

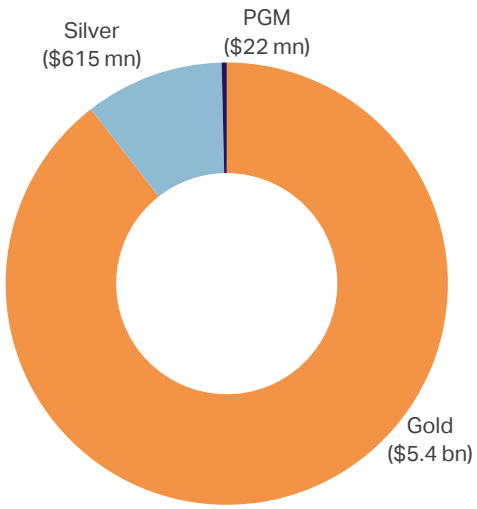
Another VAT-free option is available when silver is delivered to and stored in bonded warehouses, most commonly in Switzerland. While major dealers offer this service to both retail and institutional investors, feedback indicates that institutional investors are far more prevalent than retail ones. This explains why large bars (such as 15kg) dominate silver stored in bonded warehouses, due to the lower premiums they attract.

German Gold Physical Investment



Source: Metals Focus

German Precious Metal Physical Investment by Value*



*Annual average over 2015-24
Source: Metals Focus

Silver structured products

Unlike the products discussed above, which are backed by physical metal, retail investors can also gain leveraged exposure to silver prices through structured products such as put/call warrants, knockout warrants, and certificates. Compared to silver futures or options traded on commodity exchanges, these structured products offer greater flexibility and generally lower capital requirements, making them particularly attractive to retail investors. Structured products experienced a boom across Europe in the 2000s, until the sector was severely impacted by the 2008 financial crisis. After a prolonged period of subdued activity, investor interest in these products has improved in recent years.

Silver versus other precious metals

Within the precious metals complex, physical **gold** remains the most popular product among retail investors in value terms. For example, Germany was the largest market for gold retail investment among Western countries, and the third largest globally (after China and India), each year from 2010 to 2022. The value of physical silver investment averaged just 11% of gold investment over 2010–24, considerably lower than the ratio seen in the US.

Gold's favorable tax treatment is undoubtedly a key factor here. Unlike silver, gold bar and coin sales are exempt from VAT. Gold's dominance is also attributable to its safe-haven status. Given the macroeconomic uncertainties of the past decade or so, it is perhaps unsurprising that gold has benefited more as German investors turned to hard assets for wealth preservation.

Platinum and **palladium** investment products are also available to German retail investors. However, interest has been limited due to the 19% VAT they attract, the low public awareness of PGMs as investable assets, and the significantly wider buy-sell spreads they command. Where interest does exist, it tends to be coin-focused and appeals either to numismatic collectors or to a small number of investors seeking to diversify their gold and/or silver portfolios.

Long-Term Trends

Silver retail investment in Germany has experienced significant fluctuations since 2010. Over this period, there were two distinct phases of strong buy-side interest, 2010–11 and 2019–22, when heightened uncertainty led to markedly increased investor interest in physical silver as a means of wealth protection.

The strong opening – 2010 to 2011

Silver retail investment saw notable gains during 2010–11. Much of this was due to the lingering effects of the 2008 financial and economic crisis, followed by the European sovereign debt crisis. In particular, aggressive quantitative easing by the ECB stoked inflationary concerns. As memories of the 1920s hyperinflation resurfaced, there was a surge in demand for

hard assets. While gold was the main beneficiary of these inflows, silver also enjoyed strong positive spillovers. Silver's exceptional rally in 2010 and early 2011 further boosted investor confidence.

The lull – 2012 to 2018

Given the exceptionally strong volumes purchased during the financial and European sovereign debt crises, it was natural that such momentum would not be sustained. As the outlook for the Eurozone improved, investor interest in silver began to wane. Following a notable 36% y/y decline in 2012, silver investment stabilized, averaging 24.8Moz (771t) per annum through to 2018.

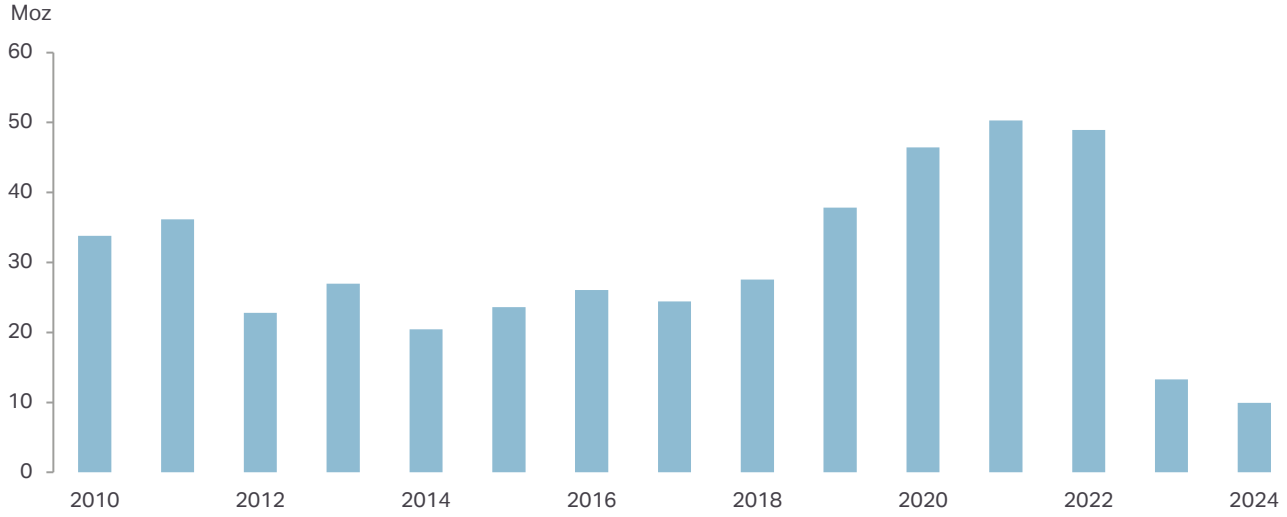
Beyond easing economic uncertainty, disappointment over silver's failure to break through the $50 mark, and its subsequent price retreat, also dampened investor sentiment. Although major price dips occasionally prompted bargain hunting, this interest was typically short-lived due to silver's prolonged price weakness. This made it difficult for the metal to compete with other assets, such as the German stock market, which enjoyed a sustained bull run during the 2010s.

That said, net retail investment during this period remained healthy in absolute terms, and well above pre-2008 crisis levels. This reflected a growing public desire to hold hard assets for wealth preservation, particularly amid continued monetary easing by the ECB, including the introduction of negative interest rates.

The robust rebound – 2019 to 2023

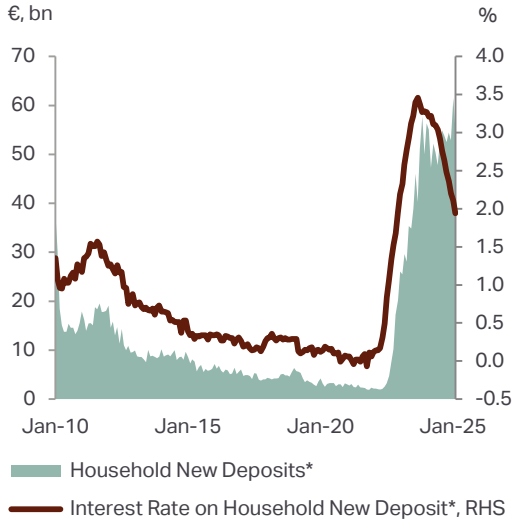
Following a period of relatively steady demand, silver investment began to rise in 2019, driven by deepening negative interest rates, a slowing economy, and growing concerns about fiat currencies. Demand was further boosted by the German government's decision to reduce the limit for anonymous cash purchases from €10,000 to €2,000, effective from the

German Silver Physical Investment



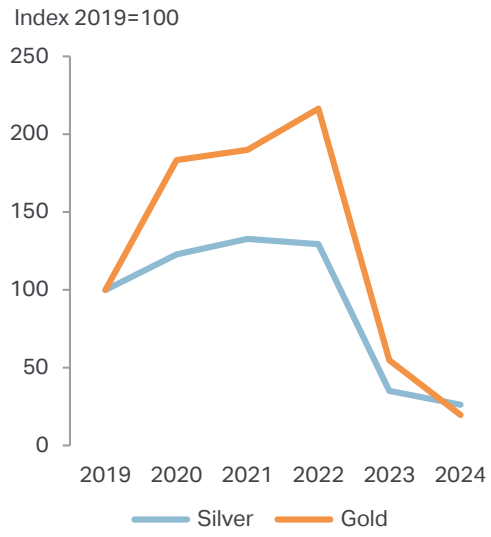
Source: Metals Focus

Interest Rates on German Household Deposits



* With maturity up to 12 months
Source: Bundesbank

German Gold & Silver Physical Investment



Source: Metals Focus

start of 2020. With a strong cultural preference for cash, concerns over trust and privacy prompted many Germans to purchase precious metals anonymously before the change took effect.

Silver investment then surged in 2020, reaching successive all-time highs through 2021 and remaining elevated in 2022. During this period, retail investment averaged 48.5Moz (1,509t), 74% above the 2010–19 average. This reflected a flight to hard assets following the COVID-19 pandemic and Russia's invasion of Ukraine. With household savings rising sharply during lockdowns, and local banks charging negative interest on deposits, German savers were strongly incentivized to seek alternative assets, with silver and gold among the main beneficiaries.

Bargain hunting also played a role. In particular, the collapse in silver prices during the early days of the pandemic, coupled with a steep rise in the gold:silver ratio, made silver appear undervalued. Despite a dramatic price rebound, silver's relatively affordable price continued to appeal to small retail investors, especially those priced out of the gold market.

As impressive as it appears, physical investment was often constrained by limited product availability, resulting in long delivery lead times and exceptionally high premiums. This is evidenced by a notable rise in sales of silver bars, which attracted far higher VAT.

The sharp pull-back – 2023

This exceptional demand came to an abrupt halt in 2023, with volumes falling by 73% to their lowest annual total since at least the 2008 financial crisis. The decline was triggered by the end of favorable VAT treatment on non-EU silver bullion coins at the start of 2023. These coins had accounted for the majority of German retail silver investment, and their removal from the margin VAT scheme was an important reason for the collapse in sales, severely denting investor sentiment.

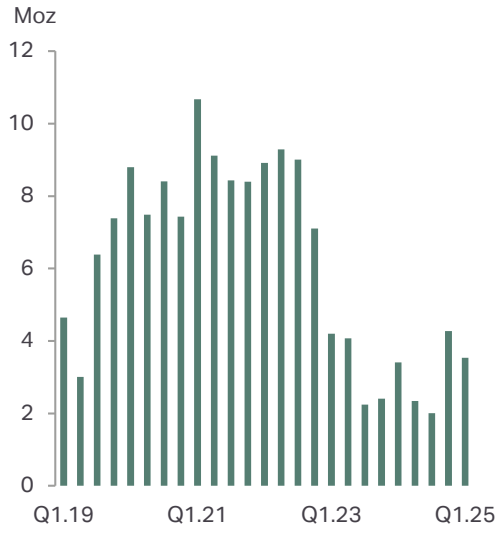
Beyond the VAT change, silver investment was also undermined by broader factors affecting precious metals. For example, gold retail investment also fell by 75%. Successive interest rate hikes by the ECB meant that savers were offered the best returns in years, and this diverted investor interest away from precious metals.

The worsening cost-of-living crisis also encouraged households to retain or generate more liquidity. Meanwhile, three years of exceptionally strong demand led to a degree of market saturation. In the absence of fresh crisis events, safe-haven demand naturally declined as the public became more accustomed to the ongoing level of geopolitical and economic uncertainty.

2024 Review

Following the sharp decline in 2023, German retail investment weakened further in 2024, falling another 25% and marking a new low in Metals Focus' series. This reflected the same factors that curtailed investor interest in

Primary Silver Bullion Coin Sales in Europe by Major Mints



Source: Various

2023: market saturation; crisis fatigue; attractive returns on bank savings, and continued cost-of-living pressures. Against this backdrop, sales of precious metal bars and coins suffered across the board.

Moreover, although a year had passed since the VAT hike on non-EU silver bullion coins, the blow to investor sentiment persisted. For German bullion wholesalers and retailers, the fact that non-EU silver coins were still subject to preferential margin VAT treatment in Poland (as they had been in Germany prior to 2023) created additional headwinds. Poland ended this margin VAT regime at the end of 2024.

The downturn in net investment was also amplified by increased profit-taking among retail investors in response to rising silver prices. That said, volumes remained relatively modest, especially compared to gold. This reflected the fact that silver prices still traded well below their all-time highs. Additionally, with higher premiums (than gold) and VAT applied to retail silver bullion products, a steeper price increase is required before investors can realize meaningful profits.

Following weak demand for much of 2024, silver investment showed tentative signs of improvement towards the end of the year. Renewed macroeconomic and geopolitical uncertainties were key drivers behind this partial rebound. As investors adjusted to new, higher prices, profit-taking slowed, providing an additional boost to net investment.

2025 Outlook

The recovery in silver investment that began in late 2024 has continued into 2025. This is reflected in Metals Focus' quarterly bullion coin survey, which shows that in Q2.25, sales of newly minted coins from leading mints recorded year-on-year growth for the third consecutive quarter. However, this improvement stems from a very weak base, and in absolute terms, net physical investment still remains low.

Elevated macroeconomic uncertainties under President Trump have been a key driver of the renewed interest in safe-haven assets so far this year. Positive price expectations have also supported investor sentiment, with bargain hunting evident in April, for example, when silver prices dipped during a global investor sell-off across asset classes. As gold prices continue to reach record highs, silver's lower entry point has made it more appealing to investors with limited budgets. That said, the 19% VAT in Germany remains a significant obstacle to investor sentiment. Another noteworthy trend is that silver bar sales appear to be performing better this year, as they are no longer perceived to be more expensive than coins following the VAT harmonization across silver bullion products.

Looking ahead, we expect this recovery to continue, supported by ongoing economic and geopolitical uncertainties that will sustain silver's (and gold's) safe-haven appeal. For the full year 2025, Metals Focus therefore forecasts a 26% increase in German net silver retail investment.

Chapter 5

Australia

Introduction

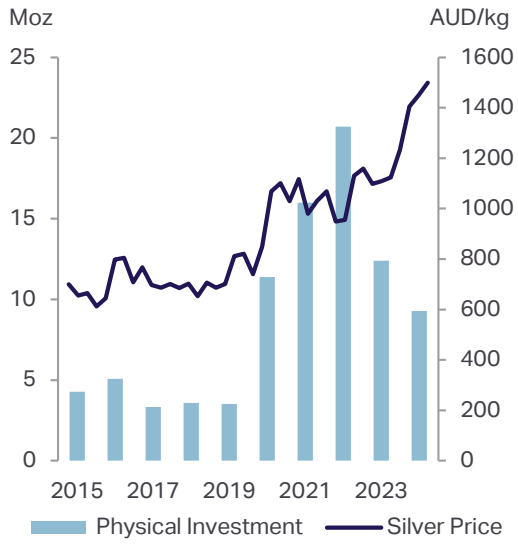
With physical investment totaling 12.2Moz (379t) in 2023, Australia became the fourth largest market globally that year. A significant chunk of growth, however, has occurred only since 2020, which saw Australia surpass China and Canada. Silver's appeal in recent years has benefited from positive price expectations and its relative value compared to gold. With the gold:silver ratio at historical highs, investors have seen better value in investing in silver.

Along with a favorable tax structure in Australia, many of the drivers of precious metals investment, such as low interest rates and worries about debasement of fiat currencies, are similar to other western markets. For instance, like many other markets, the global financial crisis in 2008 was one of the turning points. Other major events thereafter, such as the pandemic and the impact this had on monetary and fiscal policies globally, also played a role in lifting domestic silver investment demand.

The COVID-19 pandemic in particular brought about a step change in demand, which then averaged 15Moz (466t) during 2020-23, with a peak of 19.6Moz (610t) in 2022. To put this into perspective, in the decade of 2010-2019, retail investment in the country averaged just 4.6Moz (143t). Like most other markets, the factors impacting investor activity were common for both gold and silver, including inflation fears and geopolitical conflicts. Silver, however, also benefited from the belief that it was undervalued compared to gold, all of which was amplified by social media campaigns. Growing awareness about precious metals investment in superannuation or retirement accounts in Australia has also brought a significant boost to demand. While retail purchases in 2024 were estimated to have eased from the elevated levels of 2022 and 2023, it was still double that of the pre-pandemic average.

In terms of physical silver investment products, bars dominate retail purchases, with an 80-85% share, the rest being coins. 1kg cast bars are by far the most popular, although 10oz and 100oz bar volumes are sizable, both of which have gained in popularity in recent years. While local players dominate the coin market, consumers have access to products from both local and overseas providers.

Australian Silver Physical Investment



Source: Metals Focus, Bloomberg

The Structure of the Australian Silver Investment Market

Physical investment and its rival forms

While physical investment is the most popular form of silver investment in Australia retail investors also have access to other vehicles, including exchange traded products (ETPs), allocated pool offerings and mining company equities.

Australian Silver ETPs

Source: Metals Focus, Bloomberg

ETPs that are listed on the Australian Stock Exchange (ASX) offer the investor lower transaction costs and also a secure way to access physical silver via the ASX, while avoiding the need for investors to store their own bullion or pay for storage services. Gold ETPs have been available in Australia since 2003, with the first silver ETP launched in 2009. The popularity of these vehicles, however, has grown more notably in recent years. With 8.8Moz (274t) in holdings at the end of 2024, assets have more than doubled since 2019, when they stood at just 3.8Moz (118t). Although difficult to quantify, it is also worth noting that a portion of this metal is held by institutional investors.

Investors also have the option to participate in futures trading as the ASX offers CME silver future contracts. Finally, mining equities offer another route into silver, with several silver miners listed on the ASX.

Silver versus other precious metals

Silver's relative popularity compared to gold among Australian retail investors is among the highest in the world. Although gold is often the starting point for investors looking to invest in precious metals, relative allocations to silver are larger than what we see elsewhere. To give some perspective, in weight terms, the annual volume of silver retail investment has averaged 15x that of physical gold investment since 2010 and has jumped to 20x since 2020 compared to the global average of 6x (since 2010 and 7x since 2020). Apart from silver's low unit price, this mainly reflects the perception that silver is historically undervalued compared to gold, combined with expectations of superior price returns.

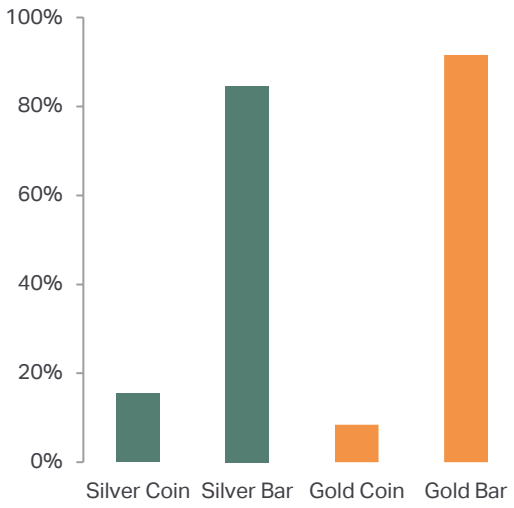
The relatively higher attraction for silver is also reflected in ETP inflows in Australia. In this regard, while gold ETP holdings have grown by 50% since the end of 2019, silver holdings have jumped by 130%.

Australia also has a very small market for PGM retail investment. Apart from physical metal, investors also have access to platinum and palladium ETPs. That said, they are not a direct rival to silver, as both PGMs are mostly traded on their industrial characteristics and investors' belief in each metal's specific supply/demand dynamics.

Taxation Structure

The tax structure in Australia is favorable for silver investment as investment grade silver (99.9% pure, hallmarked and price determined by reference to the prevailing spot price) is exempt from Goods and Services Tax (GST). While this covers both bullion bars and coins, collectibles have no tax advantage and attract 10% GST. Bars, coins and ETPs are however subject to capital tax gains (CGT), when sold at a profit. The gains are added to income for the year and are subject to tax at the marginal rate depending on the individual's income tax bracket. Silver held for more than a year is eligible for a 50% CGT discount. That aside, jewelry, bars or coins worth less than A$10,000, if declared as personal use assets (held for personal use) are CGT-exempt, regardless of how long they are held for.

Coins and Bar Share in Australia over 2015-24



Source: Metals Focus

Dividends, if any, received for silver investment through managed funds are also taxed as part of personal income. This offers an advantage to physical investment over managed funds.

When it comes to superannuation funds, the tax treatment is slightly different. During the contributory phase, when the employee is still working, short-term 15% CGT applies to precious metals that are sold, while long-term investments (of more than 12 months) attract 10% CGT. The proceeds from selling the investment, however, have to be invested back into the superannuation account during the accumulation phase. During the pension phase (when the employee is retired and drawing a pension), gains arising from selling precious metals are tax free. (For the avoidance of doubt, Metals Focus is a precious metals consultancy, not a tax advisory. This analysis is therefore provided in good faith, but does not represent tax advice.)

The product structure of Australian physical investment in silver

Bars

Australia is predominantly a bar market, with an 80-85% share of physical retail investment. Within this, cast bars account for the highest portion, with the 1kg bar being the most popular. Apart from their low premiums and higher liquidity, the relatively low price threshold to buy a kilo, particularly as it contrasts with gold (which is out of reach for an average retail investor), is a key reason for its popularity. Importantly, around 15-20% of silver investment demand is driven by self-managed superannuation accounts and since the value of such fund buying is higher, opting for a kilo or in multiples of kilo bars (which attract a lower premium compared to smaller formats), is the preferred option.

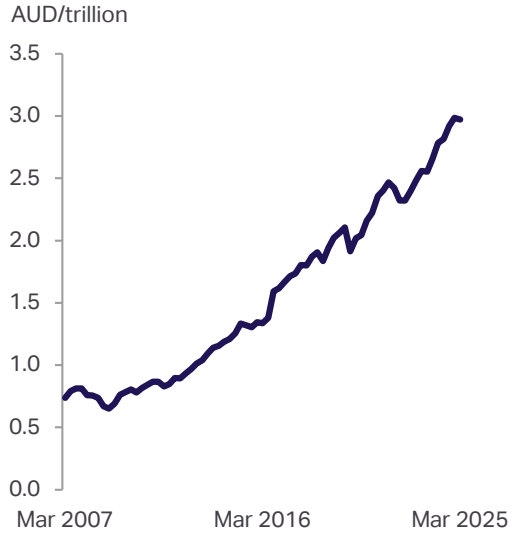
For those with larger budgets, the 100oz and 5kg bars are also popular, as they provide similar features to a kilobar when it comes to liquidity, but at a lower premium. That said, a larger bar limits the investor's ability to partially liquidate their positions, which has therefore limited the market share of such products. With the rising silver price, 10oz bars have also seen investor interest grow in recent years, albeit from a low base.

Coins

The share of coins in silver retail investment stands at between 15-20%. Demand for coins partly reflects their design and also that they provide a relatively lower price entry point for investors. Even though they command higher premiums than bars, coins are more accessible to smaller retail investors. Their smaller values are also attractive to defensive buyers that are worried about fiat currency debasement or extreme crises. Within coins, those offered by the Perth Mint, the Kangaroo, Kookaburra, Lunar series and Koala together dominate the market, all of which are backed by the government of Western Australia.

The rest of the coin market is well served by other local players, such as ABC Bullion and overseas mints including The Royal Mint, The Royal

Australian Superannuation Accounts AUM



Source: Australian Prudential Regulation Authority

Canadian Mint and the Rand Refinery, these last three respectively offering the Britannia, Maple Leaf and Krugerrand.

There is also a meaningful volume of commemorative coins minted each year in Australia (around 2Moz (62t) in 2024). While we account for the fabrication of these coins in our overall demand numbers, this is not part of our retail investment due to the very different reasons for buying them and their far higher premiums. The buying and selling of numismatic coins is also not included, as the acquisition motive and margins are very different from those of bullion coins.

Product premiums for bars and coins

In keeping with other markets, retail premiums vary considerably, depending on such factors as demand/supply of a given product and market sentiment.

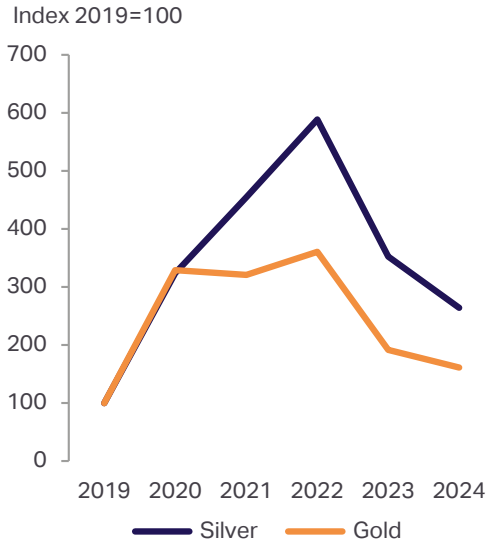
Cast bars typically feature the lowest retail premiums, which presently range from A$1.5-2.5/oz. At the time of writing, 1oz rounds have premiums ranging from A$6-12, while minted 1oz bars are slightly lower at A$6-9. Commemorative coins on the other hand command a very high premium, which at times can exceed 100%.

Long-Term Retail Investment Trends

Looking back at Australian silver investment since 2010, interest towards silver and precious metals in general picked up after the 2008 global financial crisis. Silver's price trend also played a key role in attracting investors, as the price surging to a record high in 2011 of US$49.79. Ultra-loose monetary policies, concerns about inflation and the onset of the 2010-11 Eurozone crisis saw silver demand remain elevated between 2010-2016, much like the trend seen in other major western markets such as the US. Global macro-economic stability, the rollback of monetary policy accommodation and silver's subsequent price downturn saw interest towards the metal wane notably during 2017-2019. To put the scale of this decline into context, after averaging around 5Moz (~150t) per annum during 2010-2016, demand was 30% lower during 2017-2019.

The onset of COVID and its aftermath saw a resurgence in silver investment demand. The surge in safe haven buying during the pandemic saw retail investment in Australia undergo a step change. After slumping to 3.5Moz (109t) in 2019, demand nearly tripled to 11.4Moz (355t) just a year later, before strengthening further in the coming years. A part of this was driven by aggressive lockdown restrictions during COVID, which raised concerns about government overreach. This in turn pushed investors towards non-government-controlled assets. That aside, other global factors such as worries about fiscal policies, small bank failures in the US and the social media frenzy which pushed the silver price higher helped investment sentiment, with Australia's retail investment hitting a record high of 19.6Moz (610t) in 2022.

Australian Gold & Silver Physical Investment



Source: Metals Focus

Developments in the real estate sector have also played a role in impacting local investment demand. In this regard, record low mortgage rates, an economic and jobs recovery, combined with pent-up demand in the immediate aftermath of COVID, led to a notable rise in Australian property prices during 2021 and 2022. This encouraged many investors to liquidate their real estate investment and move some of this into precious metals. That said, as property prices continued to rise and the interest rate cycle turned higher, the cost-of-living crisis became more acute. Interest rate hikes led to rising mortgage payments and this, combined with high inflation, fueled distress selling of a range of investment holdings, including silver, in the following years.

As a result, silver investment volumes fell notably in 2023 and 2024. Selling back by investors also emerged amid silver's disappointing price performance. Even so, at 9.8Moz (305t) in 2024, net silver physical investment was far above 2019's total of 3.5Moz (109t). Among the key reasons for demand to hold at these high levels has been the growing volume of silver going into superannuation accounts. These funds (a pension plan provided by a company or employer) are also a way for investors to gain exposure to silver. While those opting for self-managed funds typically buy silver bars, retail or industry superfunds usually take silver exposure through ETPs, shares in silver mining companies or through commodity funds that include silver. According to industry estimates, around 25% of superannuation funds are self-managed, with total assets under management close to A$1 trillion.

In total, Metals Focus' estimates suggest that superannuation funds now account for 15-20% of annual silver investment demand in Australia. Given how long the time horizon is for these investors, silver's higher price volatility is usually not a deterrent.

The growing popularity of cryptocurrencies has also been a factor impacting silver investment in recent years. Given the high beta associated with these investments, investors in both silver and cryptos tend to have a higher risk appetite. Our research suggests that silver faced competition from cryptocurrencies such as Bitcoin, especially in 2023 and 2024 among investors that are not risk averse.

2024 Review

Australian silver bar and coin demand saw a notable decline (25% y/y) in 2024 to 9.2Moz (287t). This was the second consecutive year of losses and the lowest total since 2019. Much like 2023, gross sales declined, while buybacks touched record levels for many dealers. Part of this reflected liquidations due to distress selling which had been triggered by the cost-of-living crisis as rising mortgage payments and high inflation weighed on consumer finances. The elevated level of silver buying over the last few years also contributed to the slowdown in 2024. For instance, cumulative bar and coin purchases surpassed 57.9Moz (1,800t) between 2020-2023. A strong Australian real estate market was another headwind for precious

metals investment, along with the growing popularity of cryptocurrencies. Our research suggests that silver's relative underperformance encouraged some investors to rotate in favor of cryptos.

That said, despite the lower total in 2024, physical investment has been structurally higher since 2020 and was still double the 2010-2019 average last year. Much of this reflected the growing awareness about precious metals as an asset class in superannuation or retirement accounts.

2025 Outlook

Judging by the response from investors so far this year, we expect physical investment to recover, albeit modestly, by 11% y/y and so partially reverse the downtrend of the last two years. Selling back by investors, although 20-30% lower than in 2024, still remains elevated on an absolute basis.

While silver's underperformance against gold at times this year may disappoint some investors who have been holding the metal, the white metal's year-to-date gains (of ~32% through to mid-August) have outpaced those of Bitcoin (up 26%), which has helped improve sentiment towards silver investment. The cost-of-living related selling of precious metals has also eased back so far this year as inflation continues to edge lower and interest rates fall. The possibility for silver to catch-up with gold's performance and potentially outperform is also expected to underpin silver investment this year. On balance, therefore, we expect physical silver investment in Australia to grow in 2025, reaching 10.3Moz (321t).

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